combine the humanisation of the workplace with environmental and health protection.

In stark contrast to Brandt's freer society, the climate of open expression that blossomed during the summer of 1971 and developed throughout the fall in East Germany began to chill. By this time, Honecker was deeply immersed in a new pet project. Having departed from the relative moderation of his first year in office, he showed more of his true colours when railing against artists and writers churning out over-critical books, films and plays. He despised 'depressing authors' penning 'private agonies, profanity, self-hatred and grief'. Works imposing 'one's own sorrows on society' were a particular bugbear which, he said, showed 'the basic attitude of such works is in contradiction to the demands socialism makes of art and literature'.

While some artists had spoken of a 'Berlin Cultural Springtime', the new First Secretary set about dismantling any such illusions. He yammered on about a play by the young writer Volker Braun which supposedly described the GDR as 'the most boring land in the world'. At the same time, he took aim at the DEFA film The Legend of Paul and Paula which depicted the life of an unskilled bottle washer and her affair with a state official. He also had caustic words for The New Sorrows of Young W, a short work of fiction based on a novel by Goethe. From here on, Honecker was quite incapable of grasping criticism and would only offer his hand to authors showing obeisance to the socialist way of life, whose works inevitably became treasures.16

In the course of 1972, Erich Honecker's bullying of writers was matched in ferocity by his offensive on the dwindling private sector. During the spring, he pushed through a forced nationalisation of remaining family businesses, which astonishingly, even in the face of government harassment and high taxes, had held their own by producing niche products that were an integral part of everyday life.

As private shops, factories and workshops were seized, owners received feeble compensation, and the chance to continue working as state-paid employees. It was no fair reckoning, especially given compensation